



Toledo council approves audit of Flock camera use



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The Blade

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Toledo City Council voted unanimously Tuesday to audit the city's use of Flock Safety cameras while allowing the cameras to remain in operation during the review.

Council voted 9-0 to request an independent audit of the city's use and oversight of the Flock system. The audit will examine how information is accessed, searched, shared, retained, and used.

Councilmen Nick Komives and Brittany Jones were absent from Tuesday's meeting, and Councilman Cerssandra McPherson was not present for the vote.

The audit comes as Toledo residents and council members have expressed increasing concerns about privacy, surveillance, and potential misuse.

It also comes as other municipalities in Ohio and across the country have cut ties with the technology.

Flock Safety's automated license plate readers photograph passing vehicles and record license plates and other identifying features in a database. Police can search the database and receive real-time alerts when a camera detects a vehicle they are seeking.

During council's [public safety committee meeting](#) on Thursday, Toledo Police Chief Michael Troendle said he is not aware of any misuse of the Flock system by Toledo officers but that he supports the independent audit.

"We won't fight the audit," Chief Troendle said. "We want our officers to be using the cameras in the correct way, and if someone is misusing our technology, we want to know about it."

While he supports the audit, Chief Troendle said he is not interested in pausing the cameras.

Although none of the council members called on the administration to pause the cameras Tuesday night, several members previously said they felt the cameras should be paused while an audit is conducted.

"I do feel like we should pause our Flock system at least during that time," Councilman Mac Driscoll previously said. "[But] that's an administrative decision."

Section 30 of the Toledo Municipal Code prohibits council members from interfering directly or indirectly with the mayor's administration. Council could request that the cameras be paused but could not require it.

Toledo Mayor Wade Kapszukiewicz confirmed after the meeting that the cameras would not be paused during the audit, but he said if the audit reveals abuse of the system, the city could turn them off.

The legislation passed by council Tuesday authorizes the city auditor to evaluate policies, procedures, and controls used to ensure that information accessed, searched, shared, retained, and used via the Flock system is for authorized and appropriate purposes.

Auditor John Rivalsky is independent of the city and works for Toledo City Council.

Some of the other items Mr. Rivalsky could review as authorized by the legislation include:

- Searches performed by city personnel.
- Searches of the city's Flock network or data by outside agencies.
- Network-sharing arrangements and controls governing access by outside agencies.
- Data-retention requirements.
- Policies, procedures, training, and other requirements governing use of the technology.
- Controls designed to identify unauthorized or inappropriate use.
- Compliance with the city's policies.

Councilman John Hobbs III, who co-sponsored the legislation with Council President Vanice Williams, estimated the audit could be complete as soon as the end of October.

In other business, council members:

- Voted 9-0 to amend the Toledo Municipal Code to [add](#) licensing requirements for hotels and motels.
- Voted 1-8 against a recycling audit contract with GT Environmental Inc. Of the members present, only Councilman Sam Melden voted in favor of the audit. Other members cited concerns with the need for the audit, as well as the funding for it.
- Gave a first reading to an ordinance that would add a chapter to the Toledo Municipal Code that would reinforce state protections for tenants from retaliatory evictions by landlords.

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